Maximum Blackouts That Keep Every Lattice Rectangle Identifiable

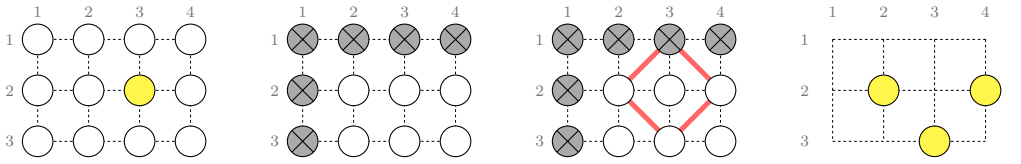
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Abstract

Kagey's Problem 001 concerns a grid of points, some of them blacked out. A rectangle with its corners on grid points, tilted or not, shows only its white corners. We ask how many points can be blacked out while every rectangle stays determined by what it shows. We study the maximum blackout and the number of optima, tabulated in A397315 and A399580 of the On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences. A row-column graph and Mantel's theorem bound the maximum by the width plus a quarter of the squared height. We find the maximum on up to five rows at every width, and on six rows from width 15 on. The five-row result refutes our earlier guess that the maximum is the sum of the two sides. We count the three-row optima exactly and find the growth rate on four rows. At every fixed height, the maximum minus the width is eventually periodic, and the optimum counts have a rational generating function. Some values rest on computer checks.

1 Introduction

You black out some points of the $h \times m$ grid, and we call this set the *blackout*. A game master draws a rectangle, tilted or not, with corners on grid points,



(a) the point $(3, 2)$ (b) our blackout (c) the rectangle (d) what we are shown

Figure 1: One round on a largest valid blackout of the 3×4 grid (Section 5). Points are (column, row). Gray crossed circles are black. Panel (c) shows the red rectangle, and (d) its yellow corners. The three yellow corners fix the fourth by Lemma 4.

and says which corners are white. You must name all four. Kagey [17, 18] asks for the largest *valid* blackout, where no two rectangles look the same (Definition 1). Figure 1 plays one round.

Let $f(h, m)$ be the largest size of a valid blackout, and $a_h(m)$ the number of valid blackouts of that size. Our OEIS entries A397315 and A399580 [30] first recorded the conjecture $f(3, m) = m + 2$ and the guess $f(h, m) = h + m$ for $\min(h, m) \geq 4$ apart from $f(4, 4) = 7$ and $f(4, 5) = 8$. The Omega Institute proved $f(3, m) = m + 2$ in Lean, in a pull request merged on 15 September 2026 [26]. Theorem 8 with Lemma 17 gives an independent proof. The guess first fails at 5×8 (Theorem 40). Put $q_h = \lfloor h^2/4 \rfloor$. Results that rest on a computer check are marked computer-assisted in their statements (Table 3).

Each part below ends with the results that prove it.

Theorem A (narrow grids)**.**

(a) We have $f(h, m) \geq h + m - 1$*, and* $f(h, m) \leq m + q_h$ *if* $m \geq 3$*.* (Lemma 17 and Theorem 8, Section 4.)

(b) We have $f(2, m) = m + 1$ *and* $f(3, m) = m + 2$ *for* $m \geq 3$*,* $f(4, m) = m+4$ *for* $m \geq 6$*, and* $f(5, 5) = 10$*.* (Theorem 5, Section 5, Theorem 31, and Theorem 44(a).)

(c) (Computer-assisted, with checked certificates for $f(5, 6)$ *and* $f(5, 7)$*, and the last claim checked in Lean.) We have* $f(4, 4) = 7$*,* $f(4, 5) = 8$*,* $f(5, 6) = 11$*,* $f(5, 7) = 12$*, and* $f(5, m) = m + 6$ *for* $m \geq 8$*.* (Corollary 32 and Theorem 40(a), (b).)

(d) *(Computer-assisted for $m \geq 9$, with checked certificates for $m \leq 14$, and checked in Lean for $m \geq 15$.) We have $f(6,m) \leq m+8$ for $8 \leq m \leq 14$, and $f(6,m) = m+9$ for $m \geq 15$.* (Theorem 42.)

(e) *(Computer-assisted, with checked certificates.) We have $f(6,6) = 12$, $f(6,7) = 13$, $f(7,7) = 14$, and $f(6,8) = 15$.* (Theorem 43.)

For (c) and (d) the finite collar theorem (Theorem 39) reduces validity at every larger width to one finite board, and Section 9 proves the SAT encodings behind the certificates faithful (Lemma 47).

Theorem B (three-row optima)**.**

(a) *For $m \geq 4$ we have $a_3(m) = 4(m-1)(3m+2)\,3^{m-5} + E_m$, where $E_m > 0$ counts the optima with a column black in rows 1 and 3 (A398448), and $E_m = O(m^2(1+\sqrt{3})^m)$. So $a_3(m) \sim \frac{4}{81} m^2 3^m$, and a fraction tending to $4/27$ of the $m^2 3^{m-1}$ axis-valid candidates is valid. The series $\sum_{m \geq 3} a_3(m) z^m$ is rational, and its denominator divides $(1-3z)^3(1-2z-2z^2)^3(1+2z^2)^3$.* (Theorem 24, Proposition 19(c), the last claims of Theorem 26, and Theorem 25(a), Section 5.)

(b) *(Computer-assisted, exact computer algebra.) This is the reduced denominator, and $E_m \sim \frac{19+11\sqrt{3}}{432} m^2 (1+\sqrt{3})^m$.* (Theorem 25(b), proved in Section 5.2, and Theorem 26.)

Theorem C (four rows)**.** *If $m \geq 4$, no valid blackout of the $4 \times m$ grid hides all corners of a rectangle* (Theorem 33)*. (Computer-assisted.) The series $\sum_{m \geq 6} a_4(m) z^m$ is rational with reduced denominator of degree 420, and $a_4(m) \sim c\, m^4 \rho_4^m$ with $c \approx 8.1611 \times 10^{-5}$ and $\rho_4 = 3.35199\ldots$, an algebraic number of degree 20* (Proposition 36, Theorem 37, and Corollary 38, Section 6)*.*

Theorem D (every fixed height)**.** *Fix $h \geq 1$ and write a blackout as the word $B_1 \cdots B_m$ of the black rows of its columns. The valid words form a regular language. If $h \geq 2$, then $f(h,m) - m$ is eventually periodic in m, and $\sum_{m \geq 0} a_h(m) z^m$ is rational.* (Theorems 45 and 46, Section 8.)

Corollary 15 proves the conjecture in A338885 that its row n has largest entry A033638(n).

Prior work. The game asks for a test cover [4, 12, 19, 24] (Corollary 3). Forbidding black axis-aligned rectangles is the Zarankiewicz problem [28]. Distinguishing them forbids four- and six-cycles in the row-column graph (Lemma 7), and de Caen and Székely [7, 8] study such graphs with unbalanced parts. Neuwirth [25, Theorem 1(ii) and Proposition 17] bounds their edges, so the row bound is known in graph form. Our proof with Mantel's theorem [20] also finds and counts the equality case. None of these works treats tilted rectangles. Column transfer [1, 9, 21], [10, Proposition V.6] handles fixed heights, and Theorem 1(3) of Guilhot, Little, and Parkinson [13] with Theorem 45 also gives Theorem D.

Outline. Sections 2 to 4 give the conventions, the strips, and the row-column graph with the general bounds. Sections 5 to 8 treat three, four, five, and six rows, and every fixed height. Section 9 describes the computations and proves the SAT encodings faithful, Section 10 lists open questions, and Appendix A treats square grids.

2 Conventions

We keep track of the black points column by column. The following notation will be used throughout.

(1) An $h \times m$ grid has h rows, m columns, and point set V. A $2 \times m$ grid is a *strip*. The point (i, j) lies in column i and row j, with $(1, 1)$ at the top left (Figure 1(a)).

(2) A *rectangle* has four grid points as corners and positive area. We write $C(R)$ for its corner set. It is *axis-aligned* if its sides follow the grid lines, and *tilted* otherwise.

(3) A *blackout* is the set $S \subseteq V$ of black points. Its *kept set* is $K = V \setminus S$, and the *presentation* $P_S(R) = C(R) \setminus S$ is what the rectangle shows, namely its white corners.

(4) Column i has *black rows* $B_i = \{j : (i, j) \in S\}$, and is *empty*, a *singleton*, a *double*, or a *triple* when $|B_i|$ is 0, 1, 2, or 3, and *full* when $|B_i| = h$. The *pair set* F is the set of row pairs contained in some B_i, and $q_h = \lfloor h^2/4 \rfloor$ is A002620(h).

Definition 1 (valid blackout)**.** A blackout S is *valid* if distinct rectangles have distinct presentations. We write $f(h, m)$ for the largest size of a valid blackout of the $h \times m$ grid, and $a_h(m)$ for the number of valid blackouts of that size. We count them with their coordinates (reflections and rotations are not identified).

Transposing the grid gives $f(h, m) = f(m, h)$ and $a_h(m) = a_m(h)$. There are no rectangles at width zero or height one, so we set $f(h, 0) = 0$, $a_h(0) = 1$, $f(1, m) = m$ and $a_1(m) = 1$. A rectangle is allowed to show no corners, but at most one can do so in a valid blackout.

Lemma 2 (difference sets)**.** *For sets A, B, and S, we have $A \setminus S = B \setminus S$ if and only if $A \triangle B \subseteq S$.*

Proof. The two visible sets agree exactly when every point belonging to just one of A and B is black, that is, belongs to S. □

Corollary 3 (hitting sets)**.** *A blackout S is valid if and only if its kept set K meets $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ for every pair of distinct rectangles R_1, R_2.*

This is Lemma 2 applied to the corner sets. Keeping an extra point cannot create an ambiguity, so every subset of a valid blackout is valid. Hence ruling out blackouts of size k also rules out every larger size.

Lemma 4 (three corners suffice)**.** *Three corners of a rectangle determine it, so distinct rectangles with the same presentation show at most two corners.*

Proof. Three corners form a right triangle, whose only right angle is at the corner q adjacent to the other two, p and r. So the fourth corner is $p + r - q$. □

3 Strips

On two rows every rectangle is axis-aligned. To see this, take a lowest corner of a tilted rectangle. Its two neighbors lie strictly above it, and the opposite corner lies above both, so the rectangle meets at least three rows. The strip problem therefore comes down to pairs of columns.

Theorem 5 (strip theorem)**.** *Let $m \geq 3$.*

(a) *A blackout of the* $2 \times m$ *strip is valid if and only if at most one of its columns is full.*

(b) *We have* $f(2, m) = m + 1$*, and the maximum blackouts are those with one full column and one black point in every other column.*

(c) *There are* $a_2(m) = m \cdot 2^{m-1}$ *maximum blackouts, so row* 2 *of* A399580 *is* A001787 *from* $m = 3$ *on.*

For $m = 2$ *there is one rectangle, so* $f(2, 2) = 4$ *and* $a_2(2) = 1$*.*

Proof. (a) Two distinct rectangles share at most one column. Their difference set therefore contains both points of at least two columns. Conversely, every pair of columns p, q occurs as a whole difference set. Choose a third column z (this is where $m \geq 3$ is used) and take the rectangles on $\{z, p\}$ and $\{z, q\}$. By Corollary 3, validity is thus equivalent to keeping a point in every pair of columns, or having at most one full column.

(b, c) We must keep at least one point in all but one column, so $|S| \leq 2m - (m - 1) = m + 1$. Equality requires one full column and exactly one black point in each other column. There are m choices for the full column, then two choices in each of the remaining $m - 1$ columns. □

Proposition 6 (orbits and kings)**.** *For* $m \geq 3$ *the number* o_m *of maximum blackouts of the* $2 \times m$ *strip up to the row reflection and the column reversal is* $m\,2^{m-3} + [m \text{ odd}]\,2^{(m-3)/2}$*. It equals* A322284$(m - 1)$*, which counts* $m - 1$ *nonattacking kings on a* $2 \times (2m - 2)$ *board up to symmetry.*

Proof. Apply Burnside's lemma to the four symmetries. The identity fixes all $m2^{m-1}$ optima, and swapping the rows fixes none. A column reversal or half turn can fix an optimum only when m is odd and the full column is central. Each then has $2^{(m-1)/2}$ fixed optima, since the singleton columns come in pairs. Dividing their sum by four gives the formula.

Put $n = m - 1$. Nonattacking kings on the $2 \times 2n$ board are columns $c_1 < \cdots < c_n$ with $c_{j+1} \geq c_j + 2$, and any rows r_j. The gaps $c_1 - 1$, $c_{j+1} - c_j - 2$, and $2n - c_n$ are nonnegative and sum to 1, so exactly one, say the eth, is 1, and $c_j = 2j - 1 + [j \geq e]$. Sending this to the optimum with full column e and other black points in rows $r_1, \ldots, r_n$ from left to right is a bijection. It commutes with the reflection, which swaps the rows on both sides, and with the reversal, which sends e to $n + 2 - e$ and c to $2n + 1 - c$ and reverses the order of the row labels, since $2n + 1 - c_{n+1-j} = 2j - 1 + [j \geq n + 2 - e]$. So the orbits correspond. □

4 The row-column graph and general bounds

A blackout S is *axis-valid* if no two axis-aligned rectangles have the same presentation. A rectangle showing at most two corners is *weak*. The *row-column graph* G_S has vertices r_j for the rows and c_i for the columns, and an edge $r_j c_i$ for each black point (i, j).

Lemma 7 (axis-aligned rectangles and short cycles)**.** *If G_S has no four-cycle and no six-cycle, then S is axis-valid. The converse holds for $m \geq 3$.*

Proof. For the converse, let $m \geq 3$. A four-cycle $r_j\, c_i\, r_{j'}\, c_{i'}$ and a third column w make $\{i, w\} \times \{j, j'\}$ and $\{i', w\} \times \{j, j'\}$ show the same points. A six-cycle $r_a\, c_x\, r_b\, c_y\, r_c\, c_z$ makes $\{x, y\} \times \{a, b\}$ and $\{y, z\} \times \{a, c\}$ black except possibly at (y, a).

For the first statement, let $R_1 \neq R_2$ be axis-aligned with the same presentation, so $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2) \subseteq S$ (Lemma 2). Opposite corners determine a rectangle, so by symmetry the common corners lie in one row a. With none, R_1 is a black four-cycle. Two, (x, a) and (y, a), leave the other rows $b \neq c$ and the black four-cycle $r_b\, c_x\, r_c\, c_y$. One, (x, a), with $R_1 = \{x, y\} \times \{a, b\}$ and $R_2 = \{x, z\} \times \{a, c\}$, gives the black six-cycle $r_a\, c_y\, r_b\, c_x\, r_c\, c_z$. □

Theorem 8 (row bound)**.** *Let $m \geq 3$. Every axis-valid blackout of the $h \times m$ grid has at most $m + q_h$ points, and at most $h + q_m$ if also $h \geq 3$. Hence $f(h, m) \leq m + q_h$.*

For each nonempty column i choose a tree T_i on B_i, and let H be their union.

Lemma 9 (row graph)**.** *Let $m \geq 3$ and let S be axis-valid. For any choice of the trees, H is simple and triangle-free, and $e(H) = |S| - t$, where t is the number of nonempty columns.*

Proof. By Lemma 7, G_S has no four-cycle, so H has no repeated edge and $e(H) = \sum(|B_i| - 1) = |S| - t$. A triangle $r_a r_b r_c$ is not in one tree. Edges from two columns i, i' put two of a, b, c in $B_i \cap B_{i'}$, and edges from three columns give a six-cycle $r_a\, c_i\, r_b\, c_{i'}\, r_c\, c_{i''}$. □

Lemma 10 (Mantel [20])**.** *Let H be a simple triangle-free graph on h vertices, let a vertex of maximum degree Δ have neighbor set A, and let B be the other $h - \Delta$ vertices, spanning $e(B)$ edges. Then*

$$e(H) = \sum_{b \in B} d(b) - e(B) \leq (h - \Delta)\Delta - e(B) \leq q_h.$$

Proof. Every edge meets B, as A is independent, and the degree sum over B counts the edges inside B twice. Also $d(b) \le \Delta$ and $(h-\Delta)\Delta \le q_h$. □

Proof of Theorem 8. Lemmas 9 and 10 give $|S| = t + e(H) \le m + q_h$. Only Lemma 7 uses a third column, so for $h \ge 3$ the transpose gives $|S| \le h + q_m$. □

Theorem 11 (equality structure)**.** *Let $h \ge 4$ and $m \ge 3$. A blackout of the $h \times m$ grid with $m + q_h$ points is axis-valid if and only if*

(a) every column is a singleton or a double,

(b) the q_h doubles have distinct row pairs, and

(c) these pairs form a balanced complete bipartite graph on the rows.

There are $p_h\,(m)_{q_h}\,h^{m-q_h}$ such blackouts, where $(m)_q$ is the falling factorial and the number p_h of balanced bipartitions of the rows is $\binom{h}{\lfloor h/2 \rfloor}$, halved for even h.

Proof. Let S be axis-valid. Equality in Lemmas 9 and 10 forces $t = m$, $e(B) = 0$, and $(h-\Delta)\Delta = q_h$ with B joined to all of A, so H is as in (c). If $|B_i| \ge 3$, some v has two neighbors u, w in T_i, and as $h \ge 4$ the part of v has another vertex z. Replacing vw by uw in T_i keeps uz and wz and makes the triangle uwz, against Lemma 9. This gives (a), and the edges of H, the row pairs of the doubles, give (b) and (c).

Conversely, (a) and (b) rule out four-cycles, and a six-cycle $r_a\,c_x\,r_b\,c_y\,r_c\,c_z$ would need the doubles $\{a,b\}$, $\{b,c\}$, and $\{a,c\}$, a triangle in (c), so Lemma 7 applies. The blackout determines, and is determined by, a bipartition, an injective map from its edges to columns, and a row for each other column. □

Corollary 12 (small widths)**.** *Let $h \ge 4$ and $3 \le m < q_h$. Then $f(h,m) \le m + q_h - 1$. In particular $f(5,5) \le 10$.*

Proof. By Theorems 8 and 11, a valid blackout of $m + q_h$ points has $q_h \le m$ doubles. Here $q_5 = 6$. □

Put $W_h = 1 + \lfloor (h-1)^2/4 \rfloor$, so $W_3 = 2$, $W_4 = 3$, and $W_5 = 5$.

Lemma 13 (leftmost corner)**.** *A tilted rectangle R has a unique corner $\ell = (x, r)$ in its smallest column, and a unique corner in its smallest row. The sides from ℓ are $(a, -b)$ and (c, d) with positive integers a, b, c, d and $ac = bd$, and the corners are*

$$(x, r), \qquad (x + a,\, r - b), \qquad (x + c,\, r + d), \qquad (x + a + c,\, r - b + d). \quad (1)$$

Its rows are $r - b$ to $r + d$, and its span *is $a + c$.*

Proof. No side is vertical, so two corners in column x would be opposite, and the other two, with mean column x, would lie in column x too. Rows are the same. So both sides from ℓ go right, one up and one down, and perpendicularity gives $ac = bd$. □

Lemma 14 (span bound)**.** *Every tilted rectangle of the $h \times m$ grid has span $a + c \le W_h$.*

Proof. Here $b + d \le h - 1$, and $(a - 1)(c - 1) \ge 0$ gives $a + c \le bd + 1 \le W_h$, since bd is an integer at most $(b + d)^2/4$. □

So W_h is A033638$(h - 1)$, attained for $h \ge 3$ and $m > W_h$ by the sides $(1, -b)$ and (bd, d) with $b + d = h - 1$ and $|b - d| \le 1$. The *height* and *width* of a rectangle are the ranges of the rows and columns of its corners.

Corollary 15 (the conjecture in A338885)**.** *For $n \ge 2$, the largest width of a tilted lattice rectangle of height n is $\lfloor n^2/4 \rfloor + 1$. So row n of A338885 has largest entry A033638(n).*

Proof. In (1) the height is $b + d = n$ and the width is $a + c \le bd + 1 \le \lfloor n^2/4 \rfloor + 1$, as in Lemma 14. The sides $(1, -b)$ and (bd, d) with $b = \lfloor n/2 \rfloor$ and $d = \lceil n/2 \rceil$ attain it. □

The *diamond* $D(i, j)$ is the square with corners $(i, j + 1)$, $(i + 1, j)$, $(i + 2, j + 1)$, and $(i + 1, j + 2)$. The rectangles A_i, B_i, C_i, and E_i have one corner in each of the columns i to $i + 3$, in the rows 3412, 3142, 2413, and 2143 from left to right.

Lemma 16 (tilted rectangles on narrow grids)**.** *The tilted rectangles of the $3 \times m$ grid are the diamonds $D(i, 1)$. Those of the $4 \times m$ grid are $D(i, 1)$, $D(i, 2)$, A_i, B_i, C_i, and E_i.*

Proof. Each listed set is a rectangle. On three rows $b = d = 1$, so $a = c = 1$ and ℓ is in row 2. On four rows either $b = d = 1$, which gives the diamonds, or $\{b, d\} = \{1, 2\} = \{a, c\}$ and ℓ is in row $1 + b$. The sides $(2, -2), (1, 1)$; $(1, -2), (2, 1)$; $(2, -1), (1, 2)$; and $(1, -1), (2, 2)$ give A, B, C, and E. □

Lemma 17 (boundary cross)**.** *The first row and the first column of the $h \times m$ grid form a valid blackout, so $f(h, m) \geq h + m - 1$.*

Proof. By Lemma 4 only presentations of at most two points matter. An axis-aligned rectangle $\{x_1, x_2\} \times \{y_1, y_2\}$ shows $X \times Y$ with $X = \{x_1, x_2\} \setminus \{1\}$ and $Y = \{y_1, y_2\} \setminus \{1\}$, which determine it, since $|X| = 1$ exactly when $1 \in \{x_1, x_2\}$, and likewise for Y. By Lemma 13 a tilted rectangle has at most two black corners, ℓ and $(x + a, r - b)$. If both are black, then $\ell = (1, 1 + b)$ and it shows $p = (1 + c, 1 + b + d)$ and $q = (1 + a + c, 1 + d)$. These determine a, b, c, d and differ in both coordinates, so no axis-aligned rectangle shows $\{p, q\}$. □

Lemma 18 (axis-aligned rivals)**.** *Let no axis-aligned rectangle be fully black. A* rival *of a set P of at most two white points is an axis-aligned rectangle that shows exactly P. The empty set has no rival, and P has one exactly when it is a singleton $\{(x, r)\}$ with $\{r, s\} \in F$ for some $s \in B_x$, a vertical pair $\{(x, r), (x, s)\}$ with $\{r, s\} \in F$, a horizontal pair $\{(x, r), (z, r)\}$ with $B_x \cap B_z \neq \emptyset$, or an oblique pair $\{(x, r), (z, s)\}$ with $x \neq z$, $r \neq s$, and $(x, s), (z, r) \in S$.*

Proof. A rival of $P \neq \emptyset$ has rows $\{r, s\}$, columns $\{x, z\}$, and its other corners black. As (x, r) is white, this is the listed condition, which forces $z \neq x$ and $s \neq r$. □

5 Three rows

Throughout, $m \geq 3$, the rows are $1, 2, 3$ from the top, and the tilted rectangles are the diamonds $D(i, 1)$ (Lemma 16). Theorem 8 and Lemma 17 give $f(3, m) = m + 2$, a result also proved by the Omega Institute [26]. The columns are $a = \{1\}$, $b = \{2\}$, $c = \{3\}$, $A = \{1, 2\}$, $B = \{1, 3\}$, $C = \{2, 3\}$, and $X = \{1, 2, 3\}$, with a and c *outer*. A blackout without empty columns is its *word* $B_1 \cdots B_m$, and each pair of F (Section 2) is named by its double letter.

Proposition 19 (the two types)**.** *Let S be a blackout of the $3 \times m$ grid with $m + 2$ points.*

(a) If S is valid, its word is one X among singletons (type T) or two different doubles among singletons (type P).

(b) For every word of type T or P, G_S is a tree, so axis-aligned rectangles have distinct presentations.

(c) There are $m3^{m-1} + \binom{m}{2} \cdot 6 \cdot 3^{m-2} = m^2 3^{m-1}$ words of type T or P.

Proof. (a) By Lemmas 9 and 10, $|S| = t + e(H)$ with $t \leq m$ nonempty columns and $e(H) \leq 2$. So every column is nonempty and $\sum_i (|B_i| - 1) = 2$, and two equal doubles would form a four-cycle in G_S, against Lemma 7. (b) The column X, or the two doubles, connect the three rows, and every other column hangs on one row. (c) Place X, or two different doubles, and choose a singleton for each other column. □

These words are the *candidates*, in the class X and the classes AC, CA, AB, BA, BC, and CB named by their doubles from left to right. Let AC_m hold the valid words of width m in AC, and likewise for the others.

Lemma 20 (diamond test)**.** *A candidate S with pair set F is valid if and only if every diamond $D(i, 1)$ passes the test below, where $P = D(i, 1) \setminus S$.*

(a) If $|P| \geq 3$ or P is empty, the diamond passes.

(b) If $P = \{(i + 1, 1), (i + 1, 3)\}$, the diamond fails if and only if $B \in F$.

(c) If $P = \{(i, 2), (i + 2, 2)\}$, it fails if and only if $B_i \cap B_{i+2}$ meets $\{1, 3\}$.

(d) If P is an oblique pair $\{(x, r), (z, s)\}$, it fails if and only if $(x, s), (z, r) \in S$.

(e) If $P = \{(x, r)\}$, it fails if and only if $\{r, s\} \in F$ for some $s \in B_x$.

Proof. Axis-aligned rectangles are told apart (Proposition 19(b)), three points fix a rectangle (Lemma 4), and an empty diamond has no axis-aligned rival, as G_S has no four-cycle. Tests (b) to (e) are Lemma 18, a rival needing $B \in F$ in (b) and $\{r, s\} \in F$ in (e). Two diamonds share at most a tip, so a common presentation would need both middle columns black in rows 1 and 3, which no candidate has. □

A *window* is three consecutive letters, at columns i to $i+2$, and *passes* or *fails* with $D(i,1)$. Its *tips* $(i,2)$ and $(i+2,2)$ are black exactly when their letters are b, A, C, or X.

Lemma 21 (singleton dichotomy)**.** *In a candidate, a window of three singletons fails if and only if $B \in F$ and it is bab, bbb, or bcb.*

Proof. With both tips black, the diamond shows the vertical pair or one point of the middle column, and tests (b) and (e) fail it exactly when $B \in F$. With one black tip it shows three corners or an oblique pair passing test (d), as $(i+1,2)$ is white. With no black tip at least three corners show. □

Lemma 22 (six of nine in the class $\{A,C\}$)**.** *Let S be a candidate with $F = \{A,C\}$, and let s,t be singletons.*

(a) A window sAt fails if and only if st is bb, bc, or cb, also for $t = C$ read as $t = b$.

(b) A window sCt fails if and only if st is bb, ba, or ab.

(c) A window with one double, at a tip, passes.

Proof. (a) Column $i+1$ shows only $(i+1,3)$, and the tip $(i+2,2)$ is black for $t \in \{b,C\}$. With both tips black, test (e) fails, as $2 \in B_{i+1}$ and $C \in F$. With only $(i+2,2)$ black, the diamond shows $(i,2)$ and $(i+1,3)$, and test (d) fails it exactly when $s = c$. The case of $(i,2)$ alone is symmetric, and with no black tip three corners show. Reflection in the middle row gives (b). (c) For Ast the proof of Lemma 21 applies with the tip $(i,2)$ in place of $s = b$, as $B \notin F$. Reflection and reversal give the other windows. □

By Lemma 20, the set AC_m holds the words $UAVCW$ of width m, with U, V, and W singleton strings, whose windows pass. Put $G_{AC}(z) = \sum_{m\geq 2} |AC_m| z^m$, define G_{AB} likewise from the words $UAVBW$, and let $G_X(z) = \sum_{m\geq 1} |X_m| z^m$ come from the words UXW. With $R = 1-3z$, nonempty singleton strings with a fixed letter next to a double have generating function z/R.

Proposition 23 (the class $\{A,C\}$)**.** *The generating function of AC is*

$$G_{AC}(z) = \frac{z^2 - 4z^3 + 10z^4 - 8z^5 - 3z^6}{(1-3z)^3}, \tag{2}$$

and

$$|AC_m| = 2(m-1)(3m+2)3^{m-5} \qquad (m \geq 4). \tag{3}$$

Proof. By Lemma 22(a) and the half turn, a window tAC passes only for $t = a$ and ACt only for $t = c$, and AtC passes by tests (b) and (e). With Lemmas 21 and 22(c), only windows with a double in the middle can fail. If V is empty, a nonempty U ends in a and a nonempty W begins with c, giving $z^2(1+z/R)^2$. If $V = t$, Lemma 22(a),(b) leaves $p_t = 3, 1, 2$ last letters for U and $q_t = 2, 1, 3$ first letters for W, for $t = a, b, c$. As $\sum p_t = \sum q_t = 6$ and $\sum p_t q_t = 13$, this gives $z^3 \sum_t (1 + p_t z/R)(1 + q_t z/R) = z^3(3 + 12z/R + 13z^2/R^2)$. If $|V| \geq 2$, each end gives $3 + 6z/R$, for v_1 alone or one of the six passing pairs (u, v_1), and the middle $1/R$, for $9z^4(1-z)^2/R^3$. The three cases sum to (2), and $[z^m]z^k R^{-3} = \binom{m-k+2}{2}3^{m-k}$ gives (3). □

Theorem 24 (the number of three-row optima)**.** *Let E_m count the optima of the $3 \times m$ grid with a column black in rows 1 and 3 (A398448). For $m \geq 4$,*

$$a_3(m) = 4(m-1)(3m+2)3^{m-5} + E_m. \tag{4}$$

Proof. Only B and X are black in rows 1 and 3, so by Proposition 19(a) these optima are those outside AC and CA. Column reversal maps AC, AB, and BC onto CA, BA, and CB, and the reflection in the middle row maps AB onto CB, so

$$a_3(m) = 2|AC_m| + 4|AB_m| + |X_m| = 2|AC_m| + E_m \qquad (m \geq 3), \tag{5}$$

and (3) gives (4). □

5.1 The generating function

Put $L = 1 - 2z - 2z^2$, $N = 1 + 2z^2$, and $D = LN$.

Theorem 25 (three-row generating function, parts (b) and (c) computer-assisted)**.**

(a) The series $\sum_{m \geq 3} a_3(m) z^m$ equals $2G_{AC} + 4G_{AB} + G_X - z - 12z^2$, with G_{AB} and G_X from Propositions 29 and 28, of denominators dividing D^3 and D^2.

(b) Its reduced denominator is exactly $Q = R^3 L^3 N^3$.

(c) With

$$\begin{aligned} P(z) = z &- 3z^2 - 34z^3 + 228z^4 - 641z^5 + 1307z^6 - 2186z^7 \\ &+ 2056z^8 - 236z^9 - 1060z^{10} + 2584z^{11} - 4264z^{12} \\ &- 1440z^{13} + 704z^{14} - 1024z^{15} + 2080z^{16} + 2176z^{17} + 384z^{18}, \end{aligned}$$

we have

$$\sum_{m\geq 3} a_3(m) z^m = \frac{P(z)}{Q(z)} - z - 12z^2. \tag{6}$$

Proof. (a) Use (5), with $z + 12z^2$ removing widths one and two. (b) See Section 5.2. (c) Exact computer algebra in SymPy [22] gives P, and an independent transfer matrix confirms (6) exactly through width 100 (`three_row_closed_form_check.py`). □

Let $\rho = 1 + \sqrt{3}$ and $\sigma = 1 - \sqrt{3}$.

Theorem 26 (three-row closed form, computer-assisted exact algebra)**.** *For every $m \geq 3$,*

$$E_m = p_+(m)\rho^m + p_-(m)\sigma^m + T_m, \tag{7}$$

where $432\, p_\pm(m) = (19 \pm 11\sqrt{3})m^2 + (61 \pm 41\sqrt{3})m + 104 \pm 28\sqrt{3}$ and $T_m = (-2)^{\lfloor m/2 \rfloor}\, \kappa(m)$ with $\kappa(m) = (2m^2 + 41m - 104)/216$ for even m and $\kappa(m) = (7m^2 - 32m - 175)/432$ for odd m. Hence $E_m \sim \frac{19+11\sqrt{3}}{432} m^2 \rho^m$. Without the computer, we have $E_m > 0$ and

$$a_3(m) = \frac{4}{81} m^2 3^m - \frac{4}{243}(m+2)3^m + O(m^2\rho^m). \tag{8}$$

Proof. By (5), the number E_m is the coefficient of z^m in $4G_{AB} + G_X$, whose denominator divides L^3N^3. Its poles $1/\rho$, $1/\sigma$, and $\pm 1/(i\sqrt{2})$ are at most triple, so beyond a polynomial part of degree one, the sequence has the form (7). Exact computer algebra gives the twelve rational coefficients. Both sides satisfy the order-12 recurrence of L^3N^3 from $m = 14$ on and agree for $m = 2, \ldots, 13$, hence always. As $|\sigma| < 1$ and $|T_m| = O(m^2 2^{m/2})$, the asymptotic of E_m follows. Without the computer, the pole $1/\rho$ of least modulus gives $E_m = O(m^2\rho^m)$, hence (8) by (4), and the cross of Lemma 17, with word $Xa \cdots a$, gives $E_m > 0$. □

5.2 The classes AB and X

This subsection proves Propositions 28 and 29 and part (b) of Theorem 25. Here $D = LN = 1 - 2z - 4z^3 - 4z^4$. A *restricted run* is a string of singletons with no two letters b at distance two. Reversal and reflection carry the next lemma to BA, BC, and CB.

Lemma 27 (forbidden windows in the classes containing B)**.** *In the class AB and the triple class, a window fails exactly when the table lists it for its class, with s any singleton.*

class	*windows*	*forbidden*
AB, X	*singletons only*	bsb
AB	*one double*	bsA, Asb, bAb, bAc, cAb, aBa, aBb, bBa, cBc
	two doubles	bAB, ABa
X	*one triple*	bsX, Xsb, aXa, aXb, bXa, bXc, cXb, cXc

Proof. Singleton windows follow from Lemma 21, and sAt as in Lemma 22(a), except that bAb now fails test (e) of Lemma 20 as $B \in F$. In sBt and sXt both corners in column $i+1$ are black, so the diamond is empty for $s = t = b$, and for outer s and t test (c) fails it exactly when $s = t$. For $s = b \neq t$ it shows $(i+2, 2)$ alone, and test (e) fails it exactly when $\{2, t\} \in F$. In uAB test (d) fails $u = b$, as $(i+2, 3)$ and $(i+1, 2)$ are black, and otherwise three corners show. In ABw the diamond is empty for $w = b$, and test (e) fails it exactly for $w = a$. In Asb and Xsb tests (b) and (e) fail the vertical pair or the point of column $i+1$. Other windows with a double or X at the left tip show three corners or an oblique pair needing the white point $(i+1, 2)$. The rest is symmetric. □

Give an outer letter bit 0 and weight 2, and give b bit 1. Let h_{ij} count, by length, the continuations of a restricted run ending in bits i, j, where b cannot follow $1, j$. Read runs $w_1 \cdots w_n$ with $n \geq 1$ outward from a double. Let g_0 and g_1 count those with w_1 a prescribed outer letter and with $w_1 = b$, and u and v the same runs with w_2, if present, outer. A fictitious letter before w_1, outer for g and b for u and v, gives $(g_0, g_1, u, v) = z(h_{00}, h_{01}, h_{10}, h_{11})$. Solving the linear system for h gives

$$Dg_0 = z(1+z+3z^2+2z^3), \quad Dg_1 = z(1+z), \quad Du = z(1+2z^2+2z^3), \quad Dv = z. \tag{9}$$

Proposition 28 (the triple class)**.** *With u and v as in (9), $G_X(z) = z\big(1 + 4u + 2v + 2u^2 + v^2\big)$, and its denominator divides D^2.*

Proof. In UXW the runs are restricted, and bsX and Xsb make the second letters from X outer. One nonempty run gives $2u + v$ on either side. With two, the window at X allows only the neighbor pairs (a, c), (b, b), and (c, a), which give $2u^2 + v^2$. □

A word of AB is $UAVBW$ with restricted runs U, V, and W. By Lemma 27, a nonempty U read from A is counted by u or v, and a nonempty W read from B by g_0 or g_1. Let ℓ_t and r_t count the allowed U and W, empty included, when t follows A or precedes B. The windows at the double give

$$(\ell_a,\ell_b,\ell_c)=(1{+}2u{+}v,\,1{+}u,\,1{+}2u),\ (r_a,r_b,r_c)=(1{+}g_0,\,1{+}g_0{+}g_1,\,1{+}g_0{+}g_1). \tag{10}$$

For $s\in\{00,10\}$ let $J_{s\beta}$ count the continuations from s ending in bit β, the empty one with $\beta=0$. Solving as for h gives, with rows s and columns β,

$$J=\frac{1}{D}\begin{pmatrix}1+2z^2+2z^3 & z+z^2\\ 1 & 2z^2+2z^3\end{pmatrix}. \tag{11}$$

Proposition 29 (the class $\{A,B\}$, polynomial form computer-assisted)**.** *With* (9) *to* (11)*,*

$$\begin{aligned}G_{AB}(z)=z^2(1+2u)(1+g_0+g_1)+z^3(\ell_a r_a+\ell_b r_b+\ell_c r_c)\\ +z^4\,(\ell_a+\ell_c,\ \ell_b)\,J\,(r_a+r_c,\ 2r_b)^T.\end{aligned} \tag{12}$$

Moreover $G_{AB}=P_B/D^3$ *with*

$$P_B(z)=z^2(1+z)(1+z^2-3z^3+4z^6+4z^7). \tag{13}$$

Proof. Split by the length k of V. For $k=0$ the windows uAB and ABw give the first term, as $u\neq b$ and $w\neq a$. For $k=1$ the window AtB passes, and uAt and tBw give $\ell_t r_t$. For $k\geq 2$ the window Av_1v_2 makes v_2 outer, $v_{k-1}v_kB$ passes, and $v_3\cdots v_k$ is a continuation from bits 00 or 10, as v_1 is outer or b, with weight $\ell_{v_1}r_{v_k}$. Since r_a+r_c counts both outer v_k, for $k\geq 3$ the weight 2 of an outer v_k in J, like the 2 in $2r_b$, counts the choices of v_2, and $k=2$ is the constant term of J. Exact computer algebra gives (13). □

Proof of Theorem 25(b). By Theorem 25(a) the denominator divides $R^3D^3=Q$. No two of R, L, and N share a root, as $D(\frac{1}{3})\neq 0$ and $L-N=-2z-4z^2$ vanishes only where $N\neq 0$. At $z=\frac{1}{3}$ only G_{AC} has a pole, and the numerator in (2) is $\frac{4}{81}$. As $P_B \bmod L=\frac{z}{2}$ and $P_B \bmod N=\frac{1}{4}-\frac{z}{2}$, at each root of D the term G_{AB} has a triple pole, G_X at most a double pole, and G_{AC} none. □

Remark 30 (optima up to symmetry). Let $o_3(m)$ count optima up to the reflection in the middle row and the column reversal. It is 15, 58, 227, 864,

3190, and 11502 at widths 3 to 8 (A401226). By Burnside's lemma, $4o_3(m)$ is $a_3(m)$ plus the optima fixed by the reflection, the reversal, and the half turn. An optimum fixed by the reflection uses only b, B, and X, so it is one X among letters b, and for $m \geq 4$ a window Xbb, bbX, or bbb fails (Lemmas 20(b) and 21), so only bXb is fixed.

Write $m = 2k$ or $m = 2k+1$. The half turn reverses the word and swaps A with C and a with c. A fixed optimum with two doubles thus has A and C at mirror positions $j \leq k$ and $m+1-j$, and center b for odd m. Its first k letters determine it, and only its windows centered at A or C can fail (proof of Proposition 23), those at C mirroring those at A. By Lemma 22(a), this leaves 3^{k-1} words in AC for $j = 1$, 3^{k-2} for $j = k \geq 2$, $2 \cdot 3^{k-2}$ for $1 < j < k$, and as many in CA. So for $k \geq 2$ there are $4k3^{k-2}$ of them, and for $m = 3$ there are AbC and CbA, with series $W = 2z^3 + \frac{4}{9}(1+z)\big(3z^2(1-3z^2)^{-2} - 3z^2\big)$.

A palindrome repeats each letter off its center, so the reversal fixes only words UXU^{rev} of odd width. There tXt passes only for $t = b$, and bsX and Xsb make the letter at distance two from X outer (Lemma 27), so U read outward is counted by v in (9). In the words $UX\iota(U^{\mathrm{rev}})$ fixed by the half turn, with ι the reflection, the central pairs (a,c), (b,b), and (c,a) pass, so U is counted by $2u+v$. Adding z^3 for bXb, $2z\big(u(z^2)+v(z^2)\big)$, and W gives

$$4\sum_{m\geq 3} o_3(m)z^m = \sum_{m\geq 3} a_3(m)z^m + z^3 + \frac{4z^3(1+z^4+z^6)}{M(1+2z^4)} + \frac{2z^3(1-z)(1+5z+3z^2-3z^3)}{(1-3z^2)^2},$$

with $M = 1 - 2z^2 - 2z^4$, since $D(z^2) = M(1+2z^4)$. A computer check (`three_row_orbits.py`) confirms the fixed counts through width 24 and $o_3(m)$ for $m \leq 10$.

6 Four rows

Theorem 31 (four rows)**.** *For every $m \geq 6$ we have $f(4,m) = m+4$.*

Theorem 8 gives the upper bound. For the lower bound take

$$S = \{(i,1) : 2 \leq i \leq m-1\} \cup \{(m-1,2),(m,2),(1,3),(2,3),(1,4),(m,4)\}. \tag{14}$$

Here $|S| = m+4$ and G_S is the eight-cycle $r_1\, c_2\, r_3\, c_1\, r_4\, c_m\, r_2\, c_{m-1}$ with leaves $c_3, \ldots, c_{m-2}$ on r_1.

Proof of Theorem 31. As G_S has no four- or six-cycle, axis-aligned rectangles have distinct presentations and none is hidden, by Lemma 7.

By Lemma 16, tilted corners are black in row 1 and white in row 4. The other black corners are $(i+2,2)$ if $i \geq m-3$ and $(i+1,3)$ if $i=1$ in $D(i,1)$, $(i,3)$ if $i \leq 2$ and $(i+1,2)$ if $i = m-2 \geq 4$ in $D(i,2)$, and $(i,3)$ if $i \leq 2$ and $(i+3,2)$ if $i \geq m-4$ in A_i and B_i. By Lemma 4 a rectangle with at most one black corner is safe, leaving those below, where $s=1$ for A_i and $s=2$ for B_i.

rectangle	which i	corners shown
$D(1,1)$		$(1,2),(3,2)$
$D(i,1)$	$i \in \{m-3, m-2\}$	$(i,2),(i+1,3)$
A_i or B_i	$i \in \{1,2\}$, $i \notin \{m-4, m-3\}$	$(i+s,4),(i+3,2)$
A_i or B_i	$i \in \{m-4, m-3\}$, $i \notin \{1,2\}$	$(i,3),(i+s,4)$
A_i or B_i	$i=2$, $m=6$	$(i+s,4)$

Shown rows differ between the first four lines, and within a line the point in row 2 or 3 fixes i and that in row 4 fixes s.

No row r has $(1,r)$ and $(3,r)$ black, so $\{(1,2),(3,2)\}$ has no rival. In the next three lines the axis-aligned rectangle through the shown points has white corner $(i,3)$, $(i+s,2)$, or $(i,4)$, respectively, since $i \geq 3$, $i+s \leq 4 < m-1$, and $3 \leq i \leq m-3$ there. In the last line $m=6$, and the shown point $(z,4)$ has $z \in \{3,4\}$ and no rival, as column z is black only in row 1 and no column is black in rows 1 and 4. □

By Theorem 11, for $m \geq 4$ the axis-valid blackouts with $m+4$ points are the $3\,(m)_4\,4^{m-4}$ *candidates*, with four doubles whose row pairs form a four-cycle F and singletons elsewhere.

Corollary 32 (widths four and five, computer-assisted)**.** *We have* $f(4,4)=7$ *and* $f(4,5)=8$.

Proof. Lemma 17 gives the lower bounds, and a computer finds a repeated presentation in all 72 and 1,440 candidates. □

Theorem 33 (no hidden rectangle)**.** *For* $m \geq 4$*, no valid blackout of the* $4 \times m$ *grid hides a rectangle.*

Proof. By Lemma 2 it suffices to write each corner set as $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ with $R_1 \neq R_2$. For an axis-aligned rectangle, keep its rows and pair each

of its columns x, y with a third column w. For $1 \le i \le m-3$ let $\mathsf{Q}_i = \{(i,2),(i,3),(i+3,2),(i+3,3)\}$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathsf{C}_i &= \mathsf{A}_i \triangle \mathsf{Q}_i, \qquad & \mathsf{E}_i &= \mathsf{B}_i \triangle \mathsf{Q}_i, \\ D(i+1,1) &= D(i,2) \triangle \mathsf{A}_i, \qquad & D(i+1,2) &= D(i,1) \triangle \mathsf{E}_i, \end{aligned} \tag{15}$$

and each solves for any of its three rectangles. The first line covers A_i, B_i, C_i, and E_i, and the second, with $i = j-1$ or $i = j$, covers $D(j,1)$ and $D(j,2)$, since $j \ge 2$ or $j \le m-3$ as $m \ge 4$. □

Theorem 34 (forbidden-block bound)**.** *For every $m \ge 6$ we have $a_4(m) \le 3\,(m)_4\,4^{m-4}(53/64)^k$, where $k = \max(0, \lfloor m/4 \rfloor - 4)$. So $a_4(m) = O\big(m^4\,212^{m/4}\big)$.*

Proof. Optima are candidates, with $3\,(m)_4$ choices of F, the double columns, and their pairs. A *block* is a run of four singleton columns, whose word lists their black rows. For a block from column x, the *template words* 2413, 3412, 2143, and 3142 are the corner rows of C_x, A_x, E_x, and B_x. Let T be one, with word $t_1t_2t_3t_4$.

A *swap word* swaps two letters t_p and t_q. No block carries one, since T and the axis-aligned rectangle on $(x+p-1, t_p)$ and $(x+q-1, t_q)$ would both show exactly these two points. Template words are the permutations with both end letters in $\{2,3\}$. Swapping two end or two middle letters gives one again, and swapping an end and a middle letter gives the sixteen with one end letter in $\{2,3\}$, so the 20 swap words are these and the four template words.

An *edit word* replaces a letter $t_p = r$ by s with $\{r,s\} \in F$. No block carries one, since T and the rectangle on rows r, s and columns $x+p-1$ and d, the double column of $\{r,s\}$, would both show only $(x+p-1, r)$. Each template word has 8 edit words. Two template words share one only if they differ in two positions holding r, s in opposite orders, and then share two if $\{r,s\} \in F$, which happens for two pairs with $\{r,s\} = \{2,3\}$ and two with $\{1,4\}$. So there are at least $32 - 8 = 24$ edit words. They repeat a letter, so none is a swap word, and at most $256 - 20 - 24 = 212 = 4^4 \cdot 53/64$ words are allowed in a block.

At most four of the $\lfloor m/4 \rfloor$ column groups $4j-3, \ldots, 4j$ contain a double column, so at least k are blocks. Other columns have at most 4 values. □

Lemma 35 (six columns of memory)**.** *Let $m \ge 6$, and let F be the edge set of a four-cycle on the rows. A word over the four singleton letters and the*

pairs of F, each pair used once, represents an optimum if and only if (i) no tilted rectangle is hidden, (ii) no tilted rectangle shares its presentation with an axis-aligned rectangle whose columns are among its own and the double columns, and (iii) no two distinct tilted rectangles in a block of at most seven consecutive columns share a presentation.

Proof. An optimum satisfies all three conditions, with (i) following from Theorem 33. Conversely, a word of the stated form is axis-valid by Theorem 11. It hides no axis-aligned rectangle, since that would give a four-cycle in G_S, and (i) excludes hidden tilted rectangles.

Suppose two distinct rectangles have the same presentation P. Then $P \neq \emptyset$, and at least one rectangle is tilted. If the other is axis-aligned, each of its columns either meets P or has two black corners. A column meeting P belongs to the tilted rectangle, and a column with two black corners is a double column. Condition (ii) therefore excludes this pair. If both rectangles are tilted, they share a column c meeting P. Each occupies at most four consecutive columns, so together they lie in columns $c-3$ to $c+3$, contrary to (iii). The word is thus valid and, with $m+4$ black points, is an optimum. □

A tilted rectangle of a word over the four singleton letters and the pairs of F *fails locally* if it is hidden, if it shows a set with a rival by Lemma 18 read with pair set F, or if another tilted rectangle of the word shows the same set.

Proposition 36 (the automaton)**.** *Let F be the edge set of a four-cycle on the rows. The automaton $\mathcal{A}_F$ reads the four singleton letters and the pairs in F. It starts at $(\epsilon, \emptyset)$, where ϵ is the empty word. A state (u, U) records the suffix of at most six letters read so far and the set $U \subseteq F$ of pairs already used.*

On reading y, it rejects if $y \in U$ or if a tilted rectangle in uy ending in the new column fails locally. Otherwise it replaces u by the suffix of uy of length $\min(6, |uy|)$ and U by $U \cup (\{y\} \cap F)$. A word is accepted if it is read to the end without rejection and the final register is $U = F$. For each $m \geq 6$, the accepted words of length m are exactly the optima of the $4 \times m$ grid with pair set F.

Proof. Fix $m \geq 6$. Tilted rectangles occupy at most four consecutive columns, so every such rectangle is contained in uy when its last column is

read. An accepted word uses each pair of F exactly once and is a candidate. Presentations with at least three points are unique by Lemma 4. The local tests exclude hidden tilted rectangles and axis-aligned rivals, giving (i) and (ii) of Lemma 35. For (iii), any two tilted rectangles in at most seven consecutive columns are both in the window when the later of their last columns is read, so the test compares their presentations. The lemma makes the word an optimum.

Conversely, an optimum of width m with pair set F uses each pair once. It hides no rectangle by Theorem 33, and no two rectangles have the same presentation. Lemma 18, applied with its pair set F, therefore finds no rival at any step. None of the local tests rejects the word, and its final register is F. □

The script `four_row_equivalence_check.py` builds $\mathcal{A}_F$ from the definition (60,975, 138,095, and 55,575 states) and checks that it accepts the same words as a smaller machine from an earlier search, whose product with the register has 2,519, 3,089, and 2,119 reachable states. Two transfer counters on that machine agree for $m \le 1500$, and a direct test of the candidates agrees for $m \le 10$ (Table 1).

m	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
$\{1,2\} \mid \{3,4\}$	0	4	128	920	4,852	24,112	114,424
$\{1,3\} \mid \{2,4\}$	20	256	1,780	11,128	63,540	346,320	1,785,768
$\{1,4\} \mid \{2,3\}$	6	32	210	1,284	7,006	32,224	137,656
$a_4(m)$	26	292	2,118	13,332	75,398	402,656	2,037,848

Table 1: Four-row optima by pair set (computer-assisted).

Theorem 37 (the four-row generating function, computer-assisted)**.** *There are coprime integer polynomials $P_4 = 26z^6 - 826z^7 + \cdots$ of degree 444 and $Q_4 = \sum_{j=0}^{420} q_j z^j$ of degree 420 with $q_0 = 1$ and $\sum_{m \ge 6} a_4(m) z^m = P_4/Q_4$. The recurrence $\sum_j q_j\, a_4(n-j) = 0$ holds for every $n \ge 445$ and fails at $n = 444$. Over the integers*

$$Q_4 = (1-z)^2(1+z)^2\, g_5^3\, \tilde{g}_5^3\, g_6^3\, g_{11}^5\, g_{17}^3\, g_{19}^3\, g_{20}^5\, g_{21}^5,$$

where g_d and $\tilde{g}_d$ are irreducible of degree d with constant term 1.

Proof. By Proposition 36, the counters count the optima. Berlekamp–Massey modulo eight primes on $a_4(m)$, $m \le 1500$, gives P_4 and Q_4. The reachable

states give a transfer matrix T_F for each F, and its state vectors $v(n) = v(0)T_F^n$ satisfy $\sum_j q_j v(n_F - j) = 0$ at $n_F = 436$, 435, and 445, so powers of T_F give the recurrence for $n \geq 445$, and $\deg P_4 = 444$ forces its failure at $n = 444$. SymPy factors Q_4. □

Corollary 38 (growth, computer-assisted)**.** *Let* $\rho_4 = 3.351996777310\ldots$ *be the largest real root of* $p(x) = x^{20}g_{20}(1/x) = x^{20} - 4x^{19} + 2x^{18} + \cdots - 26x^2 - 4x + 8$*. There is a polynomial* B *of degree* 4 *with* $a_4(m) = \rho_4^m B(m) + O((1000/341)^m)$*, so* $a_4(m) \sim c\, m^4 \rho_4^m$ *with* $c \approx 8.1611 \times 10^{-5}$*.*

Proof. Exact root isolation on the factors of Q_4 shows that $r = 1/\rho_4 = 0.29832\ldots$ is its only root of modulus at most 0.341, simple in g_{20} and so of order five. So $P_4/Q_4 = \sum_{j=1}^{5} c_j(1 - z/r)^{-j} + E(z)$, where E has coefficients $O((1000/341)^m)$ and, by coprimality, $c_5 = H(r) \neq 0$ for $H(z) = P_4(z)(1 - z/r)^5/Q_4(z)$. As $[z^m](1 - z/r)^{-j} = \rho_4^m \binom{m+j-1}{j-1}$, we get $B(m) = \sum_j c_j \binom{m+j-1}{j-1}$ and $c = c_5/24$. Interval arithmetic puts c between $8.1610970775 \times 10^{-5}$ and $8.1610970776 \times 10^{-5}$. □

7 Five and six rows

7.1 Boundary padding

For a blackout S of the $h \times m$ grid and $L, R \geq 0$, let $S_{L,R}$ add the columns $1 - L, \ldots, 0$ and $m + 1, \ldots, m + R$, each black exactly in the *padding row*, row 1 or row h.

Theorem 39 (finite collar)**.** *Let* $h \geq 3$*, fix the padding row and the padded sides, and let* L^* *and* R^* *be* W_h *of Lemma 14 on padded sides and* 0 *otherwise. Then* $S_{L,R}$ *is valid for all* $L, R \geq 0$ *vanishing on unpadded sides if and only if* S_{L^*,R^*} *is valid.*

Proof. Write $S^* = S_{L^*,R^*}$. One direction is clear. Let S^* be valid and $U = S_{L,R}$. By Lemma 13 and (1), a tilted rectangle has at most one corner in row 1 and at most one in row h. Hence a weak tilted rectangle of U has a black corner in an original column e, and by Lemma 14 its columns lie in $[e - W_h, e + W_h] \cap [1 - L, m + R] \subseteq [1 - L^*, m + R^*]$. As U and S^* agree on their common columns, it is a rectangle of S^* with the same presentation. Suppose distinct rectangles R_1 and R_2 of U have the same presentation P.

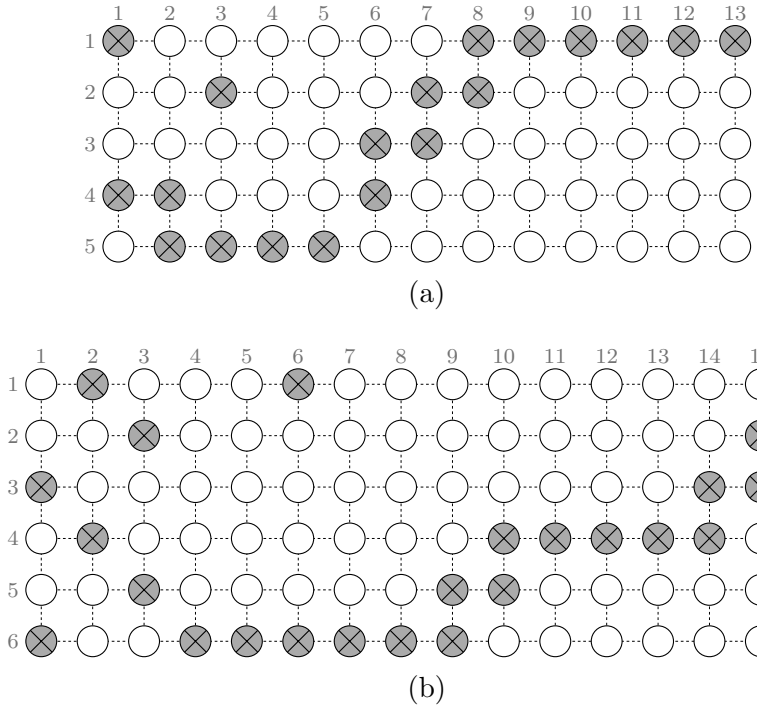


Figure 2: (a) The 5×13 test board of S_8. (b) The 6×16 blackout S_{16}.

Step 1. Both axis-aligned. Added columns are vertices of degree one, so the cycles of G_U lie in G_{S^*}. As S^* is valid with at least three columns, U is axis-valid by Lemma 7.

Step 2. Both tilted. By Lemma 4, $|P| \leq 2$, so both are weak, hence rectangles of S^* with the same presentation, a contradiction.

Step 3. One of each. Let R_1 be tilted, hence a rectangle of S^*. A column of R_2 that meets P is a column of R_1, and one that does not has two black corners and is an original column. So R_2 is a rectangle of S^* too, a contradiction. □

7.2 Five rows

We write a blackout by the black rows of its columns from left to right. Let S_8 be the blackout $14, 45, 25, 5, 5, 34, 23, 12$ of the 5×8 grid, so that $B_1 = \{1, 4\}$ and $B_4 = \{5\}$.

Theorem 40 (five rows, (a) and (c) computer-assisted, (b) checked in Lean)**.**

(a) We have $f(5, m) = m + 5$ for $m = 5$, 6, and 7.

(b) We have $f(5, m) = m + 6$ for every $m \geq 8$, attained by S_8 followed by $m - 8$ columns black in row 1 only.

(c) The 5×8 grid has exactly four maximum blackouts, the images of S_8 under row reflection and column reversal.

Proof. (b) The upper bound is Theorem 8. Since $W_5 = 5$, Theorem 39 with padding row 1 on the right reduces S_8 to the test board of Figure 2(a). Its 954 rectangles have distinct presentations, by three enumerators and Lean.

(a) For $m = 5$ the bounds are Corollary 12 and S_0 of Theorem 44. For $m = 6, 7$ the blackouts $15, 12, 23, 3, 34, 45$ and $1, 12, 23, 3, 34, 45, 15$, stored in `jis/data/small_cells_sat_5x6.json` and `jis/data/small_cells_sat_5x7_b12.json`, are valid and give the lower bound. Checked SAT certificates show that no blackout of $m + 6$ points is valid (Section 9).

(c) Two SAT enumerations and a column search over the $10\,(8)_6\,5^2 = 5{,}040{,}000$ candidates of Theorem 11 find exactly the four images. □

By Theorem A, $f(h, m) \leq h + m$ when a side is at most four, and also on the 5×5, 5×6, 5×7, and 6×6 grids. These are the other grids of area below 40, so the guess $f(h, m) = h + m$ first fails at 5×8.

Remark 41 (five-row counts, computer-assisted). For $m = 13, \ldots, 23$ the counts $a_5(m)$ are

$$193{,}406, \quad 1{,}346{,}758, \quad 8{,}650{,}416, \quad 52{,}128{,}242,$$
$$299{,}349{,}210, \quad 1{,}653{,}637{,}492, \quad 8{,}828{,}301{,}226, \quad 45{,}743{,}165{,}894,$$
$$230{,}934{,}909{,}328, \quad 1{,}139{,}486{,}126{,}866, \quad 5{,}510{,}071{,}794{,}736.$$

Two independent transfer counters based on Theorem 11 agree on each.

7.3 Six rows and small grids

Let S_{16} be the blackout of the 6×16 grid in Figure 2(b). Its doubles, in the columns $1, 2, 3, 6, 9, 10, 14, 15, 16$, carry the edges of $K_{3,3}$ between $\{1, 3, 5\}$ and $\{2, 4, 6\}$.

Theorem 42 (six rows, (a) computer-assisted, (b) checked in Lean)**.**

(a) For $8 \le m \le 14$ *we have* $f(6, m) \le m + 8$*.*

(b) For every $m \ge 15$ *we have* $f(6, m) = m + 9$*.*

Proof. (a) For $m = 8$ this is Corollary 12. For $9 \le m \le 14$, by Theorem 11 the doubles of a valid blackout of $m+9$ points carry the edges of $K_{3,3}$ for one of ten row partitions. Checked LRAT certificates for the structured encoding exclude every case (Lemma 47).

(b) The upper bound is Theorem 8. For $m = 15$ the blackout $56, 45, 34, 23, 1, 1, 14, 1, 1, 12, 36, 1, 25, 6, 16$, stored in `jis/data/six_row_sat_w15_A.json`, gives the lower bound with 24 points. For $m \ge 16$, since $W_6 = 7$, the test board of Theorem 39 adds $(17, 1), \ldots, (23, 1)$ to S_{16} of Figure 2(b). Its 4,627 rectangles have distinct presentations, by three enumerators and Lean. □

Theorem 43 (small grids, computer-assisted)**.** *We have* $f(6, 6) = 12$*,* $f(6, 7) = 13$*,* $f(7, 7) = 14$*, and* $f(6, 8) = 15$*. The blackout* $15, 1, 123, 34, 4, 4, 456, 26$ *of the* 6×8 *grid attains the last value.*

Proof. The valid blackouts $14, 1, 12, 2, 23, 3456$ of the 6×6 grid, $16, 1, 1, 12, 2, 23, 3456$ of the 6×7 grid, and $17, 1, 12, 2, 23, 3456, 67$ of the 7×7 grid, stored in `jis/data/small_cells_sat_6x6.json`, `jis/data/small_cells_sat_6x7.json`, and `jis/data/small_cells_sat_7x7.json`, give the other lower bounds. Checked SAT certificates exclude one more point in each case. □

Theorem 44 (the 5×5 grid)**.**

(a) We have $f(5, 5) = 10$*.*

(b) (Computer-assisted.) The $a_5(5) = 8$ *maximum blackouts are the images of* S_0 *below under the square's symmetries.*

Proof. (a) The upper bound is Corollary 12. For the lower bound let S_0 be $45, 34, 123, 1, 15$. Its graph is an 8-cycle with two pendant edges, so S_0 is axis-valid. By Lemma 13 its 30 tilted rectangles are nine unit diamonds, sixteen from Lemma 16, and five spanning the grid. The fifteen weak ones are listed by their two shown corners and, after a bar for an oblique pair, the white corner of its axis-aligned rectangle.

$(1,2),(2,1) \mid (1,1)$	$(1,3),(2,2) \mid (1,2)$	$(3,4),(4,3) \mid (4,4)$	$(2,5),(3,4) \mid (3,5)$
$(2,2),(4,2)$	$(1,2),(4,3) \mid (1,3)$	$(4,4),(5,2) \mid (4,2)$	$(3,5),(4,4) \mid (3,4)$
$(4,3),(5,2) \mid (4,2)$	$(3,4),(5,2) \mid (5,4)$	$(2,5),(5,2) \mid (2,2)$	$(4,5),(5,3) \mid (4,3)$
$(1,3),(4,2) \mid (1,2)$	$(2,5),(4,3) \mid (4,5)$		$(4,5),(5,4) \mid (4,4)$

The fifteen pairs are distinct, and Lemma 4 settles the other tilted rectangles. Each listed white corner lies on the only axis-aligned rectangle through its pair, and $(2,2),(4,2)$ has no rival since $B_2 \cap B_4 = \emptyset$. So S_0 is valid.

(b) Of the 44,640 sets of 10 points whose graph G_S has no four- or six-cycle, exactly the images of S_0 are valid, by three programs. □

8 Every fixed height

Fix the height h and read the grid from left to right. Its blackout is the *column word* $w = B_1 \cdots B_m$, whose letter B_i records the black rows in column i. Write $|w| = m$ and $S(w)$ for its blackout, and let $\mathcal{L}_h$ be the valid words, including the empty word. We first show that validity needs only finite memory. A bounded counter will then pick out the words with the most black points.

Theorem 45 (regularity and rational series)**.** *For every $h \geq 1$ the language $\mathcal{L}_h$ is regular, and $G_h(z,u) = \sum_{w \in \mathcal{L}_h} z^{|w|} u^{|S(w)|}$ is rational in z and u.*

Proof. The *trace* of a rectangle records, in each column, the rows of its corners. It determines the corner set. By Lemma 2, two distinct traces Y, Y' give the same presentation exactly when $Y_i \triangle Y_i' \subseteq B_i$ in every column.

The possible traces form a regular language. For an axis-aligned rectangle, choose $r < s$, read a column $\{r,s\}$, then another such column after any number of empty columns. There can also be empty columns before and after. For a tilted rectangle, Lemmas 13 and 14 leave only finitely many templates (1), each of span at most W_h, again with arbitrary empty columns on either side.

An automaton can therefore read w while guessing two rectangle traces. It checks the containment above and remembers whether the traces have differed anywhere. Accepting when they differ recognizes the invalid words. Regular languages are closed under complementation, so $\mathcal{L}_h$ is regular too.

Choose a deterministic automaton for $\mathcal{L}_h$ and give a transition reading B the weight $u^{|B|}$. If $M(u)$ is its weighted transition matrix, α its start vector and β its accepting vector, then

$$G_h(z,u) = \alpha(I - zM(u))^{-1}\beta.$$

Each word is counted once because the automaton is deterministic. Cramer's rule makes the expression rational [10, Proposition V.6]. □

Theorem 46 (fixed height)**.** *Let $h \geq 2$. (a) There are integers $m_0 \geq 3$, $p \geq 1$, and $k_0, \ldots, k_{p-1}$ such that $f(h, m) = m + k_{m \bmod p}$ for every $m \geq m_0$. (b) The series $\sum_{m \geq 0} a_h(m) z^m$ is rational, with the conventions of Section 2, and the words of optimum blackouts form a regular language.*

Proof. Put $E(w) = |S(w)| - |w|$, the number of black points beyond one per column. Every consecutive block v of a valid word is valid on its own grid. Theorem 8 bounds $E(v)$ by q_h when $|v| \geq 3$. For a shorter block, $|S(v)| \leq h|v|$ gives the common bound

$$E(v) \leq C_h := \max(q_h, 2h - 2).$$

If a valid word $w = uv$ has excess k, applying this to the prefix and suffix gives

$$k - C_h \leq E(u) = k - E(v) \leq C_h.$$

Thus, for a fixed k, only finitely many prefix excesses need to be remembered. Add this counter to an automaton for $\mathcal{L}_h$, and accept when the final excess is k. It recognizes the regular language $\mathcal{L}_{h,k}$ of valid words with that excess.

The set of lengths of a regular language is eventually periodic. For $m \geq 3$, Lemma 17 and Theorem 8 put the optimal excess between $h-1$ and q_h. There are only finitely many such k, so choose one common period p and threshold m_0 for their length sets. The largest available excess then depends only on $m \bmod p$. Calling it k_r proves (a).

For each residue r, keep the words of $\mathcal{L}_{h,k_r}$ whose lengths are at least m_0 and congruent to r modulo p. This is still a regular language. Their union, together with the finitely many shorter optimum words, is exactly the language of optimum blackouts. Its counting series is rational by the same transfer-matrix argument as above, proving (b). □

9 Computations and verification

Each computed maximum and each exact count is checked by two separately written programs. The lower bound $a_7(8) \geq 18$ comes from one enumeration. Code, data, and commands are in the repository [27], and the paths below

are relative to its folder `kagey-problems/problem001`. For each computer-assisted result, `jis/scripts/README.md` gives the command, the evidence file with its SHA-256 hash, and the stored time, and Table 3 summarizes them.

An ILP program with CBC [11] through PuLP [23] finds a smallest hitting set for the sets of Lemma 2, and brute force checks it. The SAT solvers of the searches and counts come from PySAT [15]. Column searches add columns from left to right, using $f(6,6) \le 12$ on the 6×7 and 6×8 grids and $f(6,7) \le 13$ on the 6×8 and 7×7 grids. Every stored blackout and every model of a counting program is checked against the definition.

grid	f	$a_h(m)$	by	grid	f	$a_h(m)$	by	grid	f	$a_h(m)$	by
2×2	4	1	HIB	3×8	10	45,864	IB	5×8	14	4	TSDC
2×3	4	12	HIB	3×9	11	161,992	IB	5×9	15	44	TSC
2×4	5	32	HIB	3×10	12	562,912	ITD	5×10	16	350	TSC
2×5	6	80	IB	4×4	7	316	IB	5×11	17	3,004	TSC
2×6	7	192	TI	4×5	8	1,810	IB	5×12	18	24,706	TSCM
2×7	8	448	TI	4×6	10	26	IB	6×6	12	160	ISC
3×3	5	53	IB	4×7	11	292	IB	6×7	13	2,536	SC
3×4	6	224	IB	4×8	12	2,118	IMD	6×8	15	8	SC
3×5	7	892	IB	5×5	10	8	IB	6×15	24	–	TS
3×6	8	3,420	IB	5×6	11	76	ISC	7×7	14	7,300	SC
3×7	9	12,704	IB	5×7	12	1,184	ISC	7×8	16	≥ 18	S

Table 2: Computed values for $h \le m$. H: hand, T: theorem, I: ILP (value only on 3×10, 4×8, 5×6, 5×7, and 6×6), B: brute force, D: equality candidates, C: column search, S: two SAT encodings, with complete enumeration for exact counts, M: transfer counter, –: not established. On 7×8 only a lower bound for the count is given.

Our rectangle lists agree with A085582 on squares and A289832 on the other grids.

SAT encoding A forbids each inclusion-minimal set $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$, $R_1 \ne R_2$, from being all black. Encoding B instead forbids $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ for every pair of distinct rectangles sharing a corner, and has a variable y_R for each rectangle R, forced true when its corners are black, with at most one y_R true. The structured encodings for six rows fix a partition $A \mid B$ of the rows into triples. They give each column a type, a row or one of the nine pairs meeting both A and B, which fixes its black rows, use each pair once, and keep the clauses of B that involve a tilted rectangle and can be all black. The size bound is the sequential counter of Sinz [29], written out by our generator for

the certified instances, or the totalizer [3]; each is satisfiable exactly when the bound holds.

Lemma 47 (faithful encodings)**.** *Let S be a blackout of the $h \times m$ grid, and let $\mathcal{D} = \{C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2) \mid R_1 \neq R_2\}$, where R_1 and R_2 range over rectangles of this grid.*

(a) S is valid if and only if it contains no inclusion-minimal member of $\mathcal{D}$.

(b) S is valid if and only if it hides at most one rectangle and contains no $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ for distinct rectangles R_1, R_2 sharing a corner.

(c) Suppose $h = 6$, $m \geq 3$, and S is valid with $m + 9$ points. For some partition of the rows into two triples, selecting the black-row set B_i as the type of column i extends to a satisfying assignment of the structured instance.

Proof. (a) The grid is finite, so every member of $\mathcal{D}$ contains an inclusion-minimal member. Thus S contains a member of $\mathcal{D}$ if and only if it contains a minimal one. Corollary 3 gives the claim.

(b) It remains to consider pairs with no common corner. Their symmetric difference is $C(R_1) \cup C(R_2)$, which lies in S exactly when both rectangles are hidden. The condition that at most one rectangle is hidden therefore handles precisely these pairs.

(c) By Theorem 11, the rows have a partition into two triples such that every B_i is a singleton or a pair crossing the partition, and each of the nine pairs occurs once. These choices satisfy the column-type constraints. Set each indicator y_R to 1 exactly when R is hidden. Part (b) shows that these indicators and the black points satisfy encoding B. Omitting clauses preserves satisfaction, so the assignment extends to the structured instance for this partition. □

So the models of encodings A and B, read on the points, are the valid blackouts of the required size, and by (c) and Theorem 8, if the ten structured instances of width m are unsatisfiable, then $f(6, m) \leq m + 8$.

CaDiCaL [5] gives LRAT certificates for $f(5, 6) < 12$, $f(5, 7) < 13$, $f(6, 6) < 13$, $f(6, 7) < 14$, $f(7, 7) < 15$, $f(6, 8) < 16$, $f(7, 8) < 17$, and the 70 six-row instances (widths 8 to 14, ten partitions each) behind Theorem 42(a). The seven grids use encoding A over all blackouts, and the

six-row instances use the structured encoding. Two separately written generators give the same clauses. We split the 6×8 instance into the 64 cases of its first column, and the 7×7 and 7×8 instances into 128, and the second generator checks that the cases cover every first column. All 394 proofs pass `lrat-check` of drat-trim [6, 31] and the Lean LRAT checker. The models in `jis/data/table_counts/sat_7x8_16.json` give $f(7,8) \geq 16$, so $f(7,8) = 16$. The enumeration in `jis/data/table_counts/sat2split_7x8_16.json` finds 18 valid blackouts of 16 points, so $a_7(8) \geq 18$.

statement	method; independent check	evidence
Cor. 32, Thm. 44(b)	candidates; brute force	`verify_narrow.py`
Thms. 25, 26, Rem. 30	SymPy; transfer matrix	`three_row_*.json`
Thm. 37, Cor. 38, Table 1	Prop. 36; candidates	`four_row_*.json`
Thms. 40(a), 43	encoding A, LRAT; encoding B	`unsat_certificates.json`, `small_cells_*`
Thms. 40(b), 42(b)	collar board; enumerators, Lean	`five_row_*family*`, `six_row_*w15*`
Thm. 40(c), Rem. 41	SAT, counter; candidate search, second counter	`five_row_*`
Thm. 42(a)	structured, LRAT; encoder, search	`unsat_certificates.json`, `six_row_sat_w*`
Table 2, open question 2	SAT; column search; collar test	`table_counts/*`, `six_row_collar_*`

Table 3: Computer-assisted statements, their method and check, and the evidence. Evidence files are in `jis/data`, and `verify_narrow.py` is in the problem folder.

The Lean 4 files in `../lean/KageyProblems/Problem001` of the repository prove Lemmas 2, 4, and 14, Corollary 3, Theorems 5, 8 (both orientations), and 39, and that a valid blackout hides at most one rectangle. The kernel checks that S_0, S_8, the blackout of Theorem 43, the 6×15 blackout of Theorem 42, and the 5×13 and 6×23 test boards are valid, and that $\{(1,2), (2,1), (3,2), (2,3)\}$ hides $D(1,1)$ on the 4×3 grid, so Theorem 33 needs $m \geq 4$. Hence Lean proves $f(5,m) = m+6$ for $m \geq 8$, $f(6,m) = m+9$ for $m \geq 15$, $f(5,5) \geq 10$, and $f(6,8) \geq 15$, from the three standard Lean axioms alone. Not formalized are Lemma 13, Theorem 11, $f(5,5) \leq 10$, Lemma 47, the rest of Sections 3 to 8, and Appendix A.

10 Open questions

(1) Find the rational series $\sum_{m \geq 0} a_5(m) z^m$ (Theorem 46, Remark 41) and the growth rate of $a_5(m)$.

(2) A valid 6×9 blackout of 16 points passes the test of Theorem 39 with seven columns black only in row 1 on each side, as the script `six_row_collar_6x9_check.py` checks. With Theorem 42 this gives $m + 7 \le f(6, m) \le m + 8$ for $9 \le m \le 14$. Which value holds?

(3) Is $f(h, m) = m + q_h$ for all large m when $h \ge 7$? By Theorem 39, one valid $7 \times m$ blackout of $m + 12$ points passing the collar test would settle $h = 7$.

(4) Lemma 7 and Neuwirth's bound for bipartite graphs of girth eight [25, Corollary 16] give $f(n, n) < n^{4/3} + \frac{2}{3}n - \frac{2}{9}n^{2/3} - \frac{20}{81}n^{1/3}$ for $n \ge 3$, and Theorem 50 gives $f(n, n) \ge 0.29\, n^{6/5}(1+\ln n)^{-2/5}$ for large n. Lavrov [16] used the same method for the triangular version. What is the true order, and the least n with $f(n, n) > 2n$?

11 Acknowledgments

I thank Peter Kagey for posing the problem, and for discussing its early stages with me, including the uniqueness of the 5×5 optimum and the first graph-theoretic approach to the narrow grids. The design of Figures 1 and 2 follows the figure in his posting of Problem 001 [18].

A note on the use of AI

I began this work in August and wrote the first draft and its mathematics between August and October, together with most of the Python code. I used Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic) for the October 17–19 revision, including the cut of a draft from 45 to 30 pages and the language passes. It also drew the figures in the style of Kagey's posting of the problem.

I used it to check my Python code, and it wrote further checks of the computer-assisted results. One of these, `six_row_collar_6x9_check.py`, gives the lower bound in the second open question of Section 10. It also wrote the Lean files, the LRAT certificate pipeline and the formal checks described in Theorem A and Section 9. The formalization did not change a statement of the paper or find an error or missing hypothesis. It changed how several results are established, as Section 9 describes.

I also used Claude Opus 5.5 to search the literature beyond the sources I had found. Several references came from that search. I read every cited source, including the parts supporting each citation. Later reviews with Claude Opus 5.5 and OpenAI Codex pointed out problems that I checked and corrected. Codex also revised the wording and proof exposition, including Sections 2, 3 and 8 in the present version. I checked the revisions and take full responsibility for the contents of the paper.

A Square grids

We show that $f(n, n)$ grows faster than any multiple of n.

Let $n \geq 2$, $\Lambda = 1 + \ln n$, $\mathcal{R}$ the set of rectangles of the $n \times n$ grid, tilted ones included, and d_v the number with corner v.

Lemma 48. *If rectangles $R_1 \neq R_2$ have exactly two common corners p and q, and $\{p, q\}$ is a side of both or a diagonal of both, then $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ is the corner set of a rectangle.*

Proof. For a common side, the other corners are $p + u, q + u$ and $p + v, q + v$ with $u \neq v$ nonzero and perpendicular to $q - p$, so they are distinct and form a rectangle with sides $q - p$ and $v - u$. For a common diagonal, the other corners are $o \pm u$ and $o \pm v$ with $o = (p + q)/2$, $|u| = |v|$, and $v \neq \pm u$. The segments $[o - u, o + u]$ and $[o - v, o + v]$ share midpoint and length, so they are diagonals of a rectangle. □

Let $r_2(t)$ count the integer pairs (a, b) with $a^2 + b^2 = t$, and $\tau(t)$ the number of divisors of t. By Hardy and Wright [14, Sections 16.9, 16.10, and 18.1], $r_2(t) \leq 4\tau(t)$, and each $\varepsilon > 0$ has a K_ε with $\tau(t) \leq K_\varepsilon t^\varepsilon$ for $t \geq 1$.

Let $\mathcal{A}$ consist of the sets $C(R)$ with $R \in \mathcal{R}$ and the sets $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ whose exactly two common corners form a side of one and a diagonal of the other, and $\mathcal{B}$ of the sets $C(R_1) \triangle C(R_2)$ with exactly one common corner.

Lemma 49.

(a) Each point v has $d_v \leq 8n^2\Lambda$, and $|\mathcal{R}| \leq 2n^4\Lambda$.

(b) For every $\varepsilon > 0$, $|\mathcal{A}| \leq A_\varepsilon n^{4+2\varepsilon}\Lambda$ with $A_\varepsilon = 2(1 + 16 \cdot 2^\varepsilon K_\varepsilon)$, and $|\mathcal{B}| \leq 32n^6\Lambda^2$.

(c) A blackout that contains no member of $\mathcal{A} \cup \mathcal{B}$ is valid.

Proof. (a) The sides at v are $k(a,b)$ and $l(-b,a)$ with $\gcd(a,b)=1$, $k\ge 1$, and $l\neq 0$. With $d=\max(|a|,|b|)$ there are $8d$ choices of (a,b), at most $(n-1)/d$ of k, and $2(n-1)/d$ of l. Each rectangle counts twice, so $2d_v \le \sum_{d=1}^{n-1} 16(n-1)^2/d \le 16n^2\Lambda$, and $4|\mathcal{R}| = \sum_v d_v \le 8n^4\Lambda$.

(b) A rectangle with diagonal $\{p,q\}$ is fixed by its other diagonal, an integer vector of squared length $t=|p-q|^2<2n^2$, so each side of each $R\in\mathcal{R}$ is a diagonal of at most $r_2(t)\le 4K_\varepsilon(2n^2)^\varepsilon$ rectangles. Hence $|\mathcal{A}| \le |\mathcal{R}|(1+16K_\varepsilon 2^\varepsilon n^{2\varepsilon}) \le A_\varepsilon n^{4+2\varepsilon}\Lambda$. Members of $\mathcal{B}$ come from two rectangles at a corner v, so $|\mathcal{B}| \le \sum_v \binom{d_v}{2} \le \frac{n^2}{2}(8n^2\Lambda)^2$.

(c) By Lemma 2, an invalid blackout S contains $C(R_1)\triangle C(R_2)$ for some $R_1\neq R_2$, which share at most two corners by Lemma 4. With two, this set lies in $\mathcal{A}$ by Lemma 48 or by definition; with one, in $\mathcal{B}$; with none, $C(R_1)\subseteq S$ lies in $\mathcal{A}$. □

Theorem 50 (deletion method)**.** *We have*

$$\liminf_{n\to\infty} \frac{f(n,n)\,(1+\ln n)^{2/5}}{n^{6/5}} \ge \frac{5}{6\cdot 192^{1/5}} = 0.2911\ldots.$$

In particular $f(n,n)-2n\to\infty$.

Proof. Following Alon and Spencer [2, Section 3.2], put $a=192^{-1/5}$, $T=n^{6/5}\Lambda^{-2/5}$, and $\theta = a\,n^{-4/5}\Lambda^{-2/5}\in(0,1)$, and select grid points independently with probability θ. Let X, Y, and Z count the selected points and the fully selected members of $\mathcal{A}$ and $\mathcal{B}$. Then

$$\mathbb{E}(X-Y-Z) = n^2\theta - |\mathcal{A}|\theta^4 - |\mathcal{B}|\theta^6.$$

Here $n^2\theta = aT$, and Lemma 49(b) with $\varepsilon=1/10$ gives $|\mathcal{B}|\theta^6 \le 32a^6T$ and $|\mathcal{A}|\theta^4 \le A_{1/10}a^4n^{-1/5}T$. Since $32a^5=\frac{1}{6}$, some selection S' has $X-Y-Z \ge (\frac{5}{6}a - A_{1/10}a^4n^{-1/5})T$. Deleting a point of each member of $\mathcal{A}\cup\mathcal{B}$ inside S' leaves at least $X-Y-Z$ points, valid by Lemma 49(c). So $f(n,n)/T \ge \frac{5}{6}a - A_{1/10}a^4n^{-1/5} \to 5/(6\cdot 192^{1/5})$, and $T/n\to\infty$ gives $f(n,n)-2n\to\infty$. □

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